

16.2 Personalisation

Personalisation enables you to mix and match the standard sections from across the 35 regional editions, along with custom sections created by the user. The standard Google News homepage shows you the US edition, which can be changed by clicking on the drop-down next to Top Stories and choosing the region of your choice.

Personalisation is possible even without signing in to your Google account. Doing this, however, will make it specific to the computer and browser you're using. For example, if you regularly use Firefox and if for some reason want to switch to Opera for a while, the personalisation settings won't be available in Opera. The same goes for when you open Google News on another computer. There is, however, a workaround to this problem (See box Hack: Multiple Personalised Versions Of Google News).

To eke the maximum out of personalisation, however, you'll need to log in to your Google account. Also, while you are at it, activate your Personalized Search History if you haven't already



Google recommends news stories for you

done so. If you are not sure about what we are talking about here, take a look at §7.4. The Personalized Search History saves all your searches. It works in the background to enhance your search experience by customising your search results based on the history of your searches (which make up a pattern), among other things. This is applicable to Google News as well. By logging in and activating personalised search, Google News will switch on a feature called Recommended Stories, which will appear right below the Top Stories section.

The Personalized Search history keeps track of the news you read, and as Google News gets an idea about your tastes and interests, the Recommended Stories section will begin to fill up with news that better reflects your tastes and interests. You can also click on the section heading to take you to a full page of recommended stories.

You personalise your news home page by clicking on the "Personalize (or Customize) this page" link at the top right side below the "Top Stories" banner. In the window that opens, you can drag the sections to rearrange the layout, click on each section to change it or delete it, add a new standard section, or create a custom section based on the search terms you specify.

For an example, we've decided to create a custom search section called "Zune Tracker" to track all the top news stories related to Microsoft's new media player, Zune.

In the keywords section, we specify "zune" as the keyword that Google News should search for in the news stories. Keyword search, by default,



Configure the custom section